

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Niramish Shorshe Potol

❀

Pointed Gourd in Mustard Gravy

A Temple-Style Bengali Classic

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Niramish Shorshe Potol

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Niramish Shorshe Potol

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Mustard's Vegetarian Moment

Mustard — ground into a sharp, pungent paste — is one of the defining flavors of Bengali cuisine, most famously associated with fish dishes like shorshe ilish. But mustard's role in Bengali cooking extends well beyond fish, and niramish shorshe potol, pointed gourd cooked in a vegetarian mustard gravy, shows just how well that same bold, sinus-clearing flavor translates to a plant-based dish.

"Niramish" specifically signals that this is a vegetarian preparation made without onion or garlic, following the same temple-cooking customs that shape dishes like dhokar dalna and labra — a style of cooking historically associated with religious observance and with the dietary customs followed by some Bengali widows. Potol, or pointed gourd, is a favorite vegetable for this treatment: mild and slightly sweet on its own, it takes on the sharp mustard gravy beautifully without needing to compete with it.

The dish exemplifies a particular skill in Bengali vegetarian cooking — building real depth and boldness of flavor using primarily spice and technique rather than onion, garlic, or animal protein, a constraint that Bengali niramish cooking has turned into an entire, well-loved culinary tradition of its own.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Mustard's Vegetarian Moment, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Follows the niramish (onion-and-garlic-free) tradition of Bengali vegetarian cooking, historically tied to religious customs and the dietary practices of some Bengali widows. Showcases mustard, one of Bengal's most iconic flavors, in a fully vegetarian context beyond its more famous association with fish dishes. A common home-style dish, valued for delivering bold flavor without relying on alliums or animal protein. Represents a broader Bengali culinary skill in building depth through spice and technique alone.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	20m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small blender or mortar and pestle, for the mustard paste
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Niramish shorshe potol keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — mustard-based gravies are best enjoyed relatively fresh, as the pungency can intensify and turn slightly bitter with extended storage. Reheat gently over low heat.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Potol (pointed gourd), halved lengthwise	1 lb	450 g	1 lb
Mustard seeds	2 tbsp	20 g	2 chammach
Green chilies	3–4	3–4	3–4
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Mustard oil	4 tbsp	60 ml	4 chammach
Nigella seeds (kalonji)	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Water	½ cup	120 ml	½ katori
Sugar	½ tsp	2 g	½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Potol (pointed gourd) is available fresh or frozen at South Asian grocers; if unavailable, small zucchini or a mild summer squash, though not traditional, approximates the texture reasonably well for those unable to source potol. Yellow mustard seeds give a milder result than black mustard seeds — either works, though traditional Bengali cooking often favors a mix of both for a fuller flavor.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Mustard Paste

01 SOAK THE MUSTARD SEEDS

Soak the mustard seeds in warm water for 20–30 minutes to soften them, making them easier to grind smoothly and reducing excess bitterness.

02 GRIND TO A SMOOTH PASTE

Drain and grind the mustard seeds with 1–2 green chilies and a splash of water to a smooth, pale yellow paste.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Mustard Paste, continued

Chef tip. straining the ground paste through a fine sieve removes any remaining husk fragments for an extra-smooth gravy, a small step that makes a noticeable difference in the final texture.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The mustard paste should be smooth and pourable, with a sharp, distinct aroma — this is the flavor base that defines the entire dish.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Potol

03 FRY THE POTOL

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the potol pieces along with turmeric. Fry for 5–6 minutes, turning occasionally, until lightly golden on the edges.

04 TEMPER THE NIGELLA SEEDS

Push the potol to one side and add the nigella seeds and remaining slit green chilies to the oil, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Potol, continued

05 ADD THE MUSTARD PASTE

Stir in the mustard paste, water, sugar, and salt. Cover and simmer for 10–12 minutes, until the potol is completely tender and the gravy has thickened slightly.

Color indicator. the finished gravy should be a distinct pale yellow-green, with the potol pieces tender enough to pierce easily with a fork.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Boiling the mustard paste too vigorously or for too long can bring out excessive bitterness. Keep the heat gentle once the paste is added, and don't overcook beyond the potol becoming tender.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with steamed rice, a simple and beloved Bengali vegetarian lunch dish.
- A common choice for niramish (onion-garlic-free) meals during religious observances.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl as part of a Bengali thali, showcasing its distinct pale yellow-green color.

Family Style

- A light, flavorful side dish alongside rice, dal, and a protein dish for a balanced everyday meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Flavor Right

- Soaking the mustard seeds before grinding is essential for a smooth paste and reduces unwanted bitterness.
- A touch of sugar balances mustard's natural sharpness without making the dish taste sweet.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The mustard paste can be made a few hours ahead, though this dish is best cooked and served relatively fresh.
- Potol can be pre-cut and stored refrigerated for a day if needed, speeding up final cooking.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small amount of poppy seed paste alongside the mustard for a creamier, more rounded gravy — a popular variation worth trying if you enjoy the flavor of posto from other dishes in this collection.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

130 kcal	3 g	10 g	9 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Shorshe Potol with Poppy Seed	a creamier version blending mustard and poppy seed pastes together.
Alu Potol	a version with added potato for a heartier dish.
Potol Dorma	a stuffed variation where potol is filled before cooking, a different but related preparation.

Why does my mustard gravy taste bitter?

Usually not soaking the seeds long enough before grinding, or overcooking the paste. Both soaking properly and keeping the heat gentle help avoid bitterness.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I substitute the potol?

Small zucchini or a mild summer squash works reasonably well if potol isn't available, though the flavor and texture will differ somewhat from the traditional dish.

Is this dish very spicy?

It has sharpness from the mustard rather than significant chili heat — adjust the green chilies to control the overall spice level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Potol	Bengali for pointed gourd, the primary vegetable in this dish.
Shorshe	Bengali for mustard, ground into a paste that defines this dish's gravy.
Niramish	Bengali for vegetarian, specifically meaning without onion and garlic in this context.
Kalonji	nigella seeds, used for tempering, adding a distinctive sharp aroma.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Niramish Shorshe Potol

15m	20m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Potol	450 g
Mustard seeds	20 g
Green chilies	3–4
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Mustard oil	60 ml
Nigella seeds	1 g
Water	120 ml
Sugar	2 g
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Soak the mustard seeds.** Soak the mustard seeds in warm water for 20–30 minutes to soften them, making them easier to grind smoothly and reducing excess bitterness.

02 **Grind to a smooth paste.** Drain and grind the mustard seeds with 1–2 green chilies and a splash of water to a smooth, pale yellow paste.

03 **Fry the potol.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and add the potol pieces along with turmeric.

04 **Temper the nigella seeds.** Push the potol to one side and add the nigella seeds and remaining slit green chilies to the oil, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.

05 **Add the mustard paste.** Stir in the mustard paste, water, sugar, and salt.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Potol	450 g	☐ Mustard seeds	20 g
☐ Green chilies	3–4	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Mustard oil	60 ml	☐ Nigella seeds	1 g
☐ Sugar	2 g	☐ Salt	6 g

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